

CATEGORY	The Final Tally				
	Features	Speed	Ease of use	Spyware blocked	Overall
Spybot S&D	4	5	3	4	4
PestPatrol	3	2	2	4	3
Ad-Aware	3	4	4	4	4
X-Cleaner	4	2	4	2	3
SpySweeper	4	3	4	4	4
Spyware Remover	4	2	3	2	3

and 156 associated traces in the system. After the search, the agents are placed in quarantine, and can be removed later. The spyware can then be removed from the system using the remove option. A nifty feature of Spy Sweeper is that it un-installs most applications that may not work after spyware removal—KaZaA failed to operate after the check, DAP and Weatherbug were un-installed. The cleaning time taken was 14 seconds.

Spy Sweeper features real-time protection. It protects your browser from changes in the home page settings, and also monitors the memory, and detects if any spyware is loaded in active memory.

Price: \$ 29.95 ■ Web site: www.webroot.com ■ Grade: B+

Spyware Remover

BPSS is an anti-spyware program that is loaded with features to protect you from menaces on the Internet. But the program is quite unstable and did not work reliably on our test bed.

The installation of BPSS is simple, but the scan time for the program was quite long—about 3 minutes. The results were shown in a checklist, where the spyware components could be deleted. But

the program crashed and only a few components were deleted.

The program also bundles a real time monitor, which displays spyware components as they are used. Pop-ups can be kept in check using the included pop-up program. The Internet connection settings can be restored using the program. Also, programs containing spyware can be tracked and totally un-installed.



Spyware Remover's simple interface with buttons to access most features

Price: \$ 29 ■ Web site: www.bulletproofsoft.com ■ Grade: B-

The plot thickens

The thing that became immediately apparent to us is that Anti-Spyware tools still have a long way to go. Each tool removes certain spyware, but there're always leftovers that others find and remove. What is missing is a clear definition of what these tools are supposed to remove.

So, which one should you use? On the basis of our tests Spybot comes out marginally ahead. But we can't conclusively say that any of these tools provide complete protection against all spyware. We suggest that you use two tools together—Spybot and Ad-Aware is the best combination. Remember that new spyware finds its way to your PC every day, so keep your anti-spyware tool updated, and run the scans regularly. If you do this, you can rest assured that your computing life will remain relatively private. ■

KAIZAD VAJIFDAR


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